

Nielsen Norman Group Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

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Product: GICT TransLink website

Task: Purchase an e-ticket

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

No feedback after clicking “GET YOUR E-TICKET NOW” or “View Results” user cannot tell if the action was registered.

No loading indicators, progress bars, or confirmation messages.

Recommendations

Add visual feedback on button clicks (button, state change, spinner).

Show a confirmation message or transition screen after ticket selection.

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

“View Results” is vague unclear whether results refer to search results, survey results, or trip results.

Uses “e-ticket” without explaining what that means in real-world terms (e.g., QR code, email ticket).

Recommendations

Add short explanations: “E-ticket - scan QR code at gate”.

Rename “View Results” to something specific like “View Trip Results” or “Search Schedules”.

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User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

No visible "Back" or "Cancel" option after starting an action.

No way to undo or modify a ticket selection before final purchase.

Recommendations

Add a clearly labeled "Back" or "Cancel" button on all transactional pages.

Support undo/redo or at least a confirmation dialog before finalizing.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

Only two primary actions: "Home" and "View Results" - inconsistent with typical transit sites (which show schedules, maps, fares).

No consistent visual treatment for clickable vs. non-clickable elements.

Recommendations

Follow transit website conventions: navigation links for Schedules, Maps, Fares, My Tickets.

Use standard iconography (home icon, ticket icon, search icon).

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Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

No confirmation before completing a ticket purchase - users could accidentally buy wrong ticket.

No constraints or validation on ticket quantity, date, or time before purchase.

Recommendations

Add a confirmation dialog before finalizing payment.

Disable “Proceed” until all required fields (if any) are filled.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

No visible schedule, route, or ticket options on the main screen - user must recall what they wanted to do.

No persistent display of selected origin/destination or ticket type.

Recommendations

Show recent or popular routes on the homepage.

Keep selected trip details visible during ticket purchase.

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Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts – hidden from novice users – may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

No shortcuts for expert users (e.g., keyboard shortcuts, quick reorder).

No personalization or saved preferences (e.g., favorite routes).

Recommendations

Add keyboard shortcuts (e.g., Ctrl+T for tickets, Ctrl+S for schedules).

Implement a “Favorites” or “Recent Trips” feature.

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

Irrelevant text: “This project explores Human-Computer Interaction (HCI)” - not needed for transit users.

“The Future of Public Transit, Today” is marketing fluff that adds noise.

Recommendations

Remove HCI project explanation from final UI.

Replace tagline with useful info: “Next bus in 5 min” or “Buy ticket in 2 taps”.

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Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

No error messages visible on current screenshot - but likely missing entirely.

If “View Results” fails, there’s no plain-language error or solution.

Recommendations

Use clear, human-readable error messages (e.g., “No trips found - try a different time”).

Suggest a fix inline (e.g., “Check another date”).

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Help and Documentation

It’s best if the system doesn’t need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

No contextual help for ticket purchase or schedule lookup.

No searchable help or “How to use” section.

Recommendations

Provide in-context help: “Need help? Click here for ticket guide”.

Include a simple 1-2-3 guide for first-time users.